> THE PAGANS ... CAME WITH A NAVAL FORCE TO BRITAIN LIKE STINGING HORNETS AND SPREAD ON ALL SIDES LIKE FEARFUL WOLVES, ROBBED, TORE, AND SLAUGHTERED ...
>
> **SIMEON OF DURHAM**, *HISTORIA REGUM*, 1129



Viking longship
This reconstruction of a Viking longship of the 11th century, created at Roskilde in Denmark, has demonstrated its ability to sail long distances in open water without resort to oar power.

WARS OF KING CANUTE

HELGEÅ



Date 1026
Forces Danish and English: c.600 ships; Swedes and Norwegians: c.400 ships
Losses Unknown

Location
Coast of Sweden

While Canute, king of England and Denmark, was ruling his English domains, Swedish King Anund Jacob and Norwegian King Olaf Haraldsson ravaged his Danish territories. In search of revenge, Canute led a large fleet in pursuit of the marauders. Olaf and Anund devised a trick to counter their enemy's superior force. Landing at the mouth of the Helgeå River—a site located on the Swedish coast—they had a dam constructed upstream. When Canute's war fleet was sighted, the Swedes and Norwegians hastily took to their ships and rowed out of the harbor, taking up a defensive formation offshore. Since it was late in the day and his fleet was widely dispersed, Canute sailed into the now empty harbor to spend the night. As there was limited space, most of his ships remained in open sea. The following morning his enemies breached the dam, releasing a cascade of water. Some of Canute's men were drowned. The king's own ship rode the surge out into the sea, where it was surrounded by the enemy. But Canute's vessel was so large and well defended that it could not be boarded. There was some fierce fighting before Olaf and Anund, sure that they would lose heavily once Canute's ships were properly organized for battle, decided to withdraw. Their flight confirmed Canute's dominance of Scandinavia. He replaced Olaf as king of Norway two years later.



c.990–1035

CANUTE

KING OF ENGLAND, DENMARK, AND NORWAY

Canute accompanied his father Svein Forkbeard, king of Denmark, on an invasion of England in 1013. The following year his father died and the Danish army elected him king of England, although it was only after a second seaborne invasion and much hard fighting that the Anglo-Saxons submitted to his rule. Canute succeeded his brother as king of Denmark in 1018 and, after the battle of Helgeå in 1026, also affirmed his claim to be "king of the Norwegians and some of the Swedes." He ruled his North Sea empire wisely but failed to create any political structure that could maintain it after his death.

NORWEGIAN-DANISH WAR

NISSA



Date 9 August 1062
Forces Norwegians: 150 ships; Danes: 300 ships
Losses Norwegians: unknown; Danes: more than 70 ships captured

Location
The Kattegat

Harald III Sigurdsson, also known as Harald Hardrada, was one of the most celebrated of Viking warriors. He served in the elite Varangian Guard of the Byzantine Empire before returning to become king of Norway in 1047. He also claimed the throne of Denmark, held by Svein Estridsson, a nephew of Canute. There was warfare between the two for 15 years. In summer 1062 Harald sailed south to seek battle with the Danes. He laid waste the Danish coast to draw Svein out to fight. The Danish king appeared with a far larger fleet than Harald's, but many of his followers seem to have been lacking in confidence. On either side of Svein's own vessel ships were tied together with cables, but many other Danish ships were loose and disorganized, some hanging back while others pressed forward to fight.

The battle was joined late in the day and continued through the night. Enemies assailed one another with stones and arrows, as well as closing to clash with swords and shields. The loose Danish vessels were mopped up by aggressively-led groups of Norwegian longships. Svein's ship and those tied to it in the center were finally overrun after savage fighting, although the king escaped capture. Despite the scale of the Norwegian victory, Harald made peace with Svein in 1064. Instead he pursued a flimsy claim to the English throne. Harald was killed leading an invasion of England at Stamford Bridge in 1066.